

The money conversation

A sheet for two adults considering marriage, to work through before the families discuss numbers. Each of you answers in your own column.

The four subjects are kept apart on purpose. Mahr is not the wedding. The wedding is not what either of you already owes. And none of the three is the money that leaves your account every month for people at home or abroad.

PERSON A

PERSON B

DATE

1. Mahr

This section is about mahr only — what each of you expects, and who has heard that expectation so far.

1. What do you expect the mahr to be? Write it in your own words, in whatever form you expect it.

PERSON A

PERSON B

2. Who have you said that to so far — your partner, your own family, anyone else?

PERSON A

PERSON B

3. How much of it do you expect at the nikah, and how much deferred?

PERSON A

PERSON B

4. If your family names something different from what you just wrote, what would you want to happen next?

PERSON A

PERSON B

5. Who speaks for you when that conversation happens, and have you asked them?

PERSON A

PERSON B

WHAT WE AGREE ON

WHAT WE'RE STILL DECIDING

2. The wedding — one-time expenses

This section is about the one-time cost of the wedding itself — the nikah, the walima, and whatever either side expects around them. It is separate from mahr.

1. Which parts of the wedding do you expect to pay for yourself?

PERSON A

PERSON B

2. Which parts do you expect someone else to pay for, and have you asked them?

PERSON A

PERSON B

3. Of the people who would be there, how many are there because of you?

PERSON A

PERSON B

4. What is the most you are willing to spend in total? Write your own ceiling, not a guess at what it will cost.

PERSON A

PERSON B

5. If the cost goes past that ceiling, what is the first thing you would cut — and what would you cut last?

PERSON A

PERSON B

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3. Debt either of you already carries

This section is about money either of you already owes, from before anything about this marriage was decided.

1. What do you owe right now, and to whom? Include anything that has someone else's name on it.

PERSON A

PERSON B

2. What are you paying toward it each month, and how long is left?

PERSON A

PERSON B

3. Who already knows about it — your partner, your own family, your partner's family?

PERSON A

PERSON B

4. After the marriage, do you expect this to stay yours, or to be something you both handle?

PERSON A

PERSON B

5. Is there anything here you would want settled before the nikah rather than after?

PERSON A

PERSON B

WHAT WE AGREE ON

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4. Ongoing obligations to family

This section is about money that leaves your account regularly for people outside this marriage — parents, siblings, relatives here or abroad.

1. Who do you send money to now, and how often?

PERSON A

PERSON B

2. What does that come to, against what you earn?

PERSON A

PERSON B

3. Is the amount fixed, or does it change when something happens?

PERSON A

PERSON B

4. Who knows what you send — your partner, your own family, the people you send it to?

PERSON A

PERSON B

5. After the marriage, do you expect this to stay the same, go up, or come down — and if yours and your partner's are different sizes, how do you want that handled?

PERSON A

PERSON B

WHAT WE AGREE ON

WHAT WE'RE STILL DECIDING